Akbar was not a perfect man, the insan-i-kamil of Abul Fazl's resplendent prose. His appetite for conquest was, indeed, insatiable, though it is strange to expect anything less from a sixteenth-century monarch.[9] He was not above a covert assassination or two; nor above proclaiming his Islamic credentials to Abdullah of Turan while encouraging Muslim clerics in his own court to drink wine.[10] For all his reforms of revenue, administration and welfare that so distressed his warlords, for all his controversial experiments with faith, Akbar was not as radical on questions of caste. The emperor is said to have coined the term '*halalkhor*' (literally, one who eats what is lawful, more broadly, 'one who earns an honest living'[11]) for sweepers – that is, Dalits, 'untouchables'. The name anticipates another, 'harijan' (born of God), which the third 'great' of Indian history, Mahatma Gandhi, popularized for a while. Both terms carry an air of ineffectual benevolence: neither change in terminology effected a change in the lives of those whom it renamed.[12]

Akbar was not a perfect man, but he was as great as any man can be, in that he strove for perfection not through power, but through its just exercise. This was what lay at the crux of Akbar's enquiries into faith. 'The King was always pondering in his mind which nation has retained the true religion of God; and to this question he constantly gave the most earnest thought,' writes Father Monserrate. The question – How I wish for the coming of some pious man, who will resolve the distractions of my heart! – possessed the emperor, in his solitary meditations, in the gladiatorial combats of the Ibadat Khana, in the perplexing fits that sometimes overtook him.

A less imaginative man might well have remained caught in this imperative, that only one faith can make one empire, but Akbar, striding into storms of ideas and opinions as audaciously as he rode into the monsoon-heavy waters of the Ganga, was not that man. 'By God,' he once exclaimed when Father Monserrate himself thought he might have gone too far in his criticism of Islam, 'I am not the man to have my feelings outraged by these things.' He was, instead, the man to have his intelligence aroused. As men of many faiths argued around him, Akbar stopped looking for the one true belief that would bring peace to all men. Instead, he turned the whole proposition on its head and decided to make that very peace for all, the sulh-i kul, the principle tenet of his rule.